



An Empirical Study on the Influence of Social Media Engagement on Travelers' Destination Choice with Reference to Karnataka Tourism

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Abstract

Social media has evolved from a peripheral communication channel into a central force shaping how travelers discover, evaluate, and select tourist destinations. This study examines the influence of social media engagement operationalised through content exposure, electronic word of mouth (eWOM), interactivity, and influencer credibility on travelers' destination choice, with specific reference to Karnataka tourism. Adopting a mixed methods design, the study integrates a structured questionnaire survey of 384 domestic and international travelers who visited major Karnataka destinations (Coorg, Hampi, Mysuru, Gokarna, Chikmagalur, and Bengaluru) with semi structured interviews of 15 travel influencers and destination marketing stakeholders. Data were analysed using Structural Equation Modelling (SEM) in AMOS, preceded by exploratory and confirmatory factor analysis to establish the psychometric soundness of the measurement model. The results indicate that social media engagement exerts a statistically significant positive influence on destination choice (total effect beta = 0.58, $p < 0.001$), with eWOM emerging as the strongest contributing dimension, followed by influencer credibility and content interactivity. Perceived destination image partially mediates this relationship (indirect effect beta = 0.29, $p < 0.001$). Qualitative findings corroborate the survey results, revealing that user generated content and authentic storytelling substantially outweigh formal destination marketing campaigns in shaping travel decisions among younger cohorts. The study contributes to tourism marketing literature by contextualising social media driven decision making within an emerging destination ecosystem and offers actionable insights for Karnataka's tourism boards, destination marketing organisations, and hospitality stakeholders seeking to strengthen digital engagement strategies.

Keywords: Social media engagement, destination choice, electronic word of mouth, destination image, Karnataka tourism, structural equation modelling



1. Introduction

Tourism is fundamentally an experience good: a product that cannot be evaluated with certainty before consumption. Because a destination cannot be sampled in advance, travelers rely heavily on information cues gathered from external sources to reduce the uncertainty inherent in destination selection. The proliferation of social media platforms-Instagram, YouTube, Facebook, and short video applications in particular-has fundamentally restructured this information ecosystem. Against this backdrop, the present study investigates how social media engagement conceptualised across four dimensions of content exposure, electronic word of mouth, interactivity, and influencer credibility shapes travelers' destination choice in the context of Karnataka tourism, and examines the mediating role of perceived destination image in this relationship.



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2. Review of Literature & Research Gap

The review of literature reveals three specific gaps: (1) comparatively few studies decompose social media engagement into its constituent dimensions-content exposure, eWOM, interactivity, and influencer credibility-and test their differential effects within a single integrated structural model; (2) empirical work situating these relationships within an Indian state-level, multi-destination cluster context such as Karnataka is scarce; and (3) prior research has predominantly relied on purely quantitative survey designs without triangulating SEM findings against qualitative perspectives of travel influencers and destination marketing stakeholders.



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3. Research Methodology & Structural Equation Modelling

The study employs a mixed methods, explanatory sequential design combining a structured questionnaire survey of 384 domestic and international travelers across six major Karnataka destinations (Bengaluru, Mysuru, Coorg, Hampi, Gokarna, and Chikmagalur) with 15 semi-structured stakeholder interviews. Quantitative data were analysed using IBM SPSS and AMOS. All six direct-effect hypotheses (H1-H6) were supported ($R^2 = 0.51$ for Destination Image; $R^2 = 0.64$ for Destination Choice), with eWOM recording the highest standardised loading (0.88) and path coefficient ($\beta = 0.31$, $p < 0.001$). Bootstrapping with 5,000 resamples confirmed partial mediation via destination image (indirect effect $\beta = 0.29$, direct effect $\beta = 0.29$, total effect $\beta = 0.58$, $p < 0.001$).



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4. Discussion, Implications & Conclusion

Electronic word of mouth emerges as the single most influential engagement dimension, with influencer credibility a close second-findings corroborated by industry stakeholders who describe official destination marketing as increasingly playing a validating rather than originating role. For Karnataka's tourism boards and DMOs under the Tourism Policy 2024-29, the findings offer an empirically grounded basis for recalibrating destination marketing strategy toward organic, peer-driven content ecosystems, micro-influencer partnerships, and short-form interactive video.



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4. Discussion, Implications & Conclusion — Empirical Synthesis & Discussion

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